God's Favorite

By Neil Simon

NOTE: *Sidney Lipton could be played by either gender.*

Joe is forlorn and defeated. He sighs mournfully. The room is in darkness except for the moonlight shining through the French door. He looks up and speaks softly and reverently)

JOE: **(Pg 494-495)** Am I wrong? ... Is all of this too much for one family? If it is, then why did You give it to me? It's enough already, dear Lord. Don't give me any more. . . Just David. Give me back my David . . . If it be Your Will, dear God, that's all I ask. Amen!

LIPTON'S VOICE: *(A voice from somewhere in the room itself, is heard)* Amen!

JOE: *(stops in his tracks, then wheels around, shocked)* ***What?*** Who's there? Who said that?

LIPTON'S VOICE: Don't worry. It's not who you're thinking.

JOE: Who is it? I can't see you.

LIPTON'S VOICE: I can't see you either. I lost my glasses. Are the lights on or off? I can't see a damn thing.

JOE: Stay where you are! Don't move. I could have the police here in two minutes.

LIPTON'S VOICE: You're lucky. In my neighborhood you could wait for them all night! Would you please turn the lights on? I get very nervous in the dark.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Imagine if God sent a messenger to your house, but instead of a glowing angel with wings,*
ACTOR 2: *You got Sidney Lipton: a twitchy, cinematic-obsessed person in a "G" sweatshirt who acts like a pizza delivery driver bringing a box full of disasters*
ACTOR 1: *A cosmic intern who's just trying to hit his plague-delivery quota so he doesn't get fired.*
ACTOR 2: *Will Joe renounce the Almighty or will he remain . . .*
TOGETHER: *God's Favorite by Neil Simon*

JOE: **(Pg 495-509)** *(turns on lights)* All right, now who do you -- *(But there is no one there)* Where are you? ... **WHERE ARE YOU?** *(He turns around quickly ... Silence. From behind the huge sofa, SIDNEY LIPTON appears, crawling and feeling the rug with his hands)*

LIPTON: Don't get excited, I'm just looking for my glasses. *(Continues to search. Not a very*

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impressive-looking person, wearing khaki slacks, a thin raincoat, white sweat socks, Hush Puppies, a tweed cap -- a potpourri of cheap clothes) I still can't see. Where am I, on the floor?

JOE: What do you mean by breaking into my house? Who are you?

LIPTON: *(Still feeling around on the floor)* Oh, gorgeous rug. This is all handwoven. Must have cost a fortune. What is it, Persian?

JOE: Never mind the rug, I asked you a question. Who are you?

LIPTON: *(Still on his knees)* The name is Lipton. Sidney Lipton... Where am I, still on the floor?

JOE: *(Takes the glasses out of his pocket)* Here. Here's your glasses.

LIPTON: You found them? *(Puts out his hand)* Oh, good. Could you put them in my hand, please? *(Joe puts the glasses into Lipton's hand)*

LIPTON: *(Puts the glasses on, still on their knees)* Ohh. Ohh, yes, there we are ... *(looks up)* Ohhh! *This -- this* is gorgeous! *This* is what I call a gorgeous room.

JOE: Is that why you broke in here?

LIPTON: Certainly not. I'm here on business. *Very* important business.

JOE: If you have business with me, you make an appointment like everyone else.

LIPTON: *(Looking around)* I'm ***not*** like everyone else. *(Points to an ornate armchair)* I love the chair. I don't fall in love easily, but I am in love with this chair.

JOE: Is that what you are? An antique dealer?

LIPTON: Antiques? No. Antiquity, perhaps.

JOE: What does that mean?

LIPTON: What does **anything** mean? What is the meaning of "meant"? What is real or unreal? What the hell are we talking about? I'm still dizzy from that fall I took.

JOE: I can't make you out. You're not a burglar, that I can tell.

LIPTON: A burglar? No. An antique dealer? No. But who am I? What am I? Why am I here? That's the mystery, isn't it? God, I love a good mystery.

JOE: If you don't tell me who you are . . .

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LIPTON: Ah, ah, you're losing patience, aren't you? Mustn't lose patience, Joe. All in good time. I have cramps in the head. Did you ever get cramps in the head?

JOE: A lunatic! A lunatic wandered into my house from the snow. Why do I bother talking to you?

LIPTON: Curiosity! There is something curious about me, you've got to admit ... All right, enough chitchat. Let's get down to brass tacks, Joe Benjamin. Why, at this hour, on this night, in this year, in this house, on this rug, in these shoes, do I, Sidney Lipton stand before you? WHAT BUSINESS DO WE, STRANGERS TILL NOT FIVE MINUTES AGO, HAVE UNTO EACH OTHER?

JOE: Are you selling something? If you're a salesman, I'll kill you with my bare hands!

LIPTON: Do I look like a salesman? I am a man of flair, of fancy, a bizarre and unique guide to the world beyond our world.

JOE: A travel agent? Is that what you are, a travel agent?

LIPTON: *(Yells, angrily)* ***You have no imagination!*** What do I have to do to tell you who I am? Think, Joe, think!

JOE: I think you're a ***nut,*** that's what I think, and I want you out! *(He grabs Lipton by the arm)* Out, do you hear me? OUT!

LIPTON: Easy, easy. No rough stuff, I'm not a physical person.

JOE: Ten seconds and I throw you out that window head-first. One, two--

LIPTON: Don't force my hand. I deal a heavy hand

JOE: Three, four-

LIPTON: *(Stops; points a finger)* ***STAY! I STAY YOU!*** Yea, you would banish He who brings thee the gift of life and the eternal bliss? ... Forget that! Forget I said that. That was a slip. A boo-boo. Slipsies!

JOE: There's something funny going on here. You're not who you pretend to be at all, are you?

LIPTON: Aha! Aha, getting somewhere. Getting warm ...

JOE: This is all an act. A game. . . Somebody sent you, didn't they?

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LIPTON: Hot! Getting hot!

JOE: Somebody sent you to get something from me!

LIPTON: Hotter! Hotter! Boiling hotter!

JOE: Somebody important who knows me sent you to get something that I have that has enormous value. Something I have that no other man on earth has.

LIPTON: Scalding! Steaming lava! Two weeks in a sauna bath!

JOE: My Bible! My Gutenberg Bible!

LIPTON: Cold. Freezing cold. Winter. A room for two in Toronto.

JOE: Damn you, what is it?

LIPTON: Hey! Hey hey hey! Calm, please. Take it easy. Let's not break our blood vessels. The last thing I want is for you to get sick. I mean, you ***are*** in good health, aren't you?

JOE: *(Knocks wood)* Thank God!

LIPTON: *Hot! Boiling hot! Getting hot again!*

JOE: *(Screams)* What are you saying? You're driving me crazy with these stupid games.

LIPTON: Temper, temper. And I was told you were such a patient, wonderful man.

JOE: Who told you? Who told you I was a wonderful man?

LIPTON: *(Softly; side of their mouth)* You know. . . ***He*** did.

JOE: Who's he?

LIPTON: He! Him! Capital "H," small "i" small "m" ... Do I have to spell it out for you? Went on and on about you. I'll tell you the truth, you're His favorite. Yes, you, Joe Benjamin, are considered to be His -- that's capital "H" again -- His absolute favorite. And that is the honest to God's truth. *(makes a cross on his chest, then a circle, a square, all sorts of signs)*

JOE: I can't understand what you're saying.

LIPTON: ***Can't*** understand or ***afraid*** to understand?

JOE: I'm not afraid of anything on the face of this earth except God himself.

LIPTON: BINGO! BULL'S-EYE! Ding-a-ling-a-ling-aling! Fire, fire, fire! Home run, home

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run! *(jumps around in an excited jig)*

JOE: STOP IT! I beg of you to stop it and tell me who you are, in plain, simple language. Who are you, please?

LIPTON: *(stands erect, clasps his fingers together; solemnly)* Very well. Forgive me, my son. I have taken this bizarre form, so that I might present myself to you in some acceptable dimension, for had I told you the truth straight on of my identity, even I could not have given you the power to accept or comprehend. Yes, Joe -- I am -- who you think I am!

JOE: Are you trying to tell me that you're -- that you're -- are you trying to tell me --

LIPTON: Say it, Joe. You will only believe if you say the words yourself.

JOE: ***God?*** Are you trying to tell me that you're ***God?***

LIPTON: Who? . . . God? GOD? Is ***that*** what you thought? Nothing personal, but that's really crazy. Do I look like God? Would God wear glasses? I mean, if anyone's going to have good eyes, it's going to be God. No, Joe, I'm sorry to disappoint you, but I am not God.

JOE: Then who are you?

LIPTON: I'm a friend of God's. Not a ***close*** friend. We met a few times.

JOE: You met God?

LIPTON: Twice on business, once on a boat ride.

JOE: What business? *What business do you have with God?*

LIPTON: *I deliver messages!*

JOE: You're a messenger from God?

LIPTON: Important documents only; no packages.

JOE: All right, if you're who you say you are

LIPTON: I am.

JOE: Let me finish!

LIPTON: When you finish, I am!

JOE: If you're a messenger of God -- then where do you come from?

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LIPTON: Oh, you mean like heaven? The Eternal Paradise? A place like that?

JOE: Yes.

LIPTON: Jackson Heights. It's in Queens, just over the Triborough Bridge.

JOE: But you said you met God.

LIPTON: Not face-to-face. There's always a big light over Him -- the glare is murder.

JOE: GOD! GOD! HAVE YOU SEEN GOD?

LIPTON: I didn't actually ***see*** Him. I ***heard*** Him. He blessed me.

JOE: God blessed you?

LIPTON: I sneezed and God blessed me -- what do you want from me? *(Loudly)* I cannot deliver God's message until you accept that I am God's messenger! What do I need to prove it to you, *wings?*

JOE: Tell me ***why****?* Then maybe I'll believe you. ***Why*** would God send a message to me, Joe Benjamin, a plain, simple, ordinary man?

LIPTON: *To test your faith, that's why!* ... Strike that! You didn't hear it! Erase! I'm not supposed to tell you that.

JOE: Test my faith? ***My*** faith? Are you saying that God doesn't believe my faith in Him?

LIPTON: Oh, no. Not-Him. ***He*** believes! God's crazy about you ... It's the other one. *(Softly, slyly)* You know the ***other*** one. From downstairs ... Mr. Nasty … Bad, Bad Leroy Brown ... Oh, for God's sakes, you have to spell out ***everything*** for you ... Satan! Lucifer! The ***Devil,*** all right?

JOE: *(Moving toward the phone)* I've wasted enough time with you, I'm calling the police!

LIPTON: *(Points a finger again)* ***Stay! I stay you! I render you powerless!*** All right, I can't do it. I'll tell you everything . . . God and Satan were sitting around having one of those boring philosophical debates -- this was a week ago Tuesday. And Satan was sitting there in this pink suit -- gorgeous tan, little mole on his cheek ... And Satan says there is not one man on the face of the earth, who would not renounce God once the Devil put enough heat on. To which ***God*** said -- this is a quote, "***one*** man would never renounce. And that man is ... *(Makes a bugle sound)* Tatum ta tum ta

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tum ta tum ta taaa ... JOE BENJAMIN!" Thrills, right? ... So they make a bet and the bet is, the Devil will make your life so miserable, you'll renounce God!

JOE: You think I would renounce God? You think so little of man that he would renounce *God* in the face of adversity?

LIPTON: I've seen people with a burning engine on a 747 who would sell out God in a second for a little good news from the pilot *(Takes out a folded, dirty scrap of paper)* You ready?

JOE: Let me see that.

LIPTON: *(Pulls it away)* I have to read it. It's not official unless I read it ... "To Joseph Melvin Benjamin, devoted husband and father ... if pain, calamity and disaster do not in any manner whatsoever appeal to you, then renounce your God!" That's it! Message delivered. No tip necessary, Good night, good luck, God bless you ... but I doubt it! *(puts the message back in their pocket)*

JOE: I will *never* renounce God, do you hear me? I fear Him and love Him but come hell or high water, I will never renounce Him!

LIPTON: Can I be honest? You can count on the hell and high water. Good luck, Joe. And no matter what terrible things happen to you, remember that God loves you! *(a fire engine clanging in the distance)*

JOE: What's that? What's going on out there?

LIPTON: *(Looks out the window)* Looks like a fire. Near the water ... Where's your factory?

JOE: Near the water.

LIPTON: Ohh ... Look at that burn. Like a cardboard box ... What do you make?

JOE: Cardboard boxes.

LIPTON: Ohh ... Well, I wouldn't worry unless I got a phone call. *(Phone rings. They both look at it)*

JOE: It's not my plant. My plant is a hundred percent fireproof. *(picks up the phone)* Hello? Eddie? ... What is it? ... What? ... *What?*

LIPTON: One more "what" and you're in trouble.

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JOE: *(Into the phone)* WHAT?

LIPTON: What is it, a disaster or a calamity?

JOE: *(Into the phone)* The *whole plant?*

LIPTON: Oh, a catastrophe, wonderful!

JOE: Thank you, Eddie ... I know it wasn't your fault. *(He hangs up)*

LIPTON: How much did the insurance cover?

JOE: *(Dazed)* I didn't have insurance. I didn't believe in insurance ... GOD was my insurance.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil Simon
Book: The Collected Plays of Neil Simon, Volume II; Pgs 475 - 548
ISBN: 978-0452263581
Publisher: Penguin Publishing Group
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1986

AWARD HISTORY

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